NUTRITION & FOOD LABELS

The basics of eating well without making it complicated, and how to read the Nutrition Facts label in under a minute.

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GUIDE / VERIFY: General wellness information, not medical advice. It does not replace care from a doctor, nurse, pharmacist or other qualified professional. **Talk to your health-care provider before starting a new exercise, diet or health plan, especially if you have a medical condition.**

1. THE BASICS

The 2025–2030 Dietary Guidelines for Americans center on **real, minimally processed food**: protein foods, vegetables, fruits, dairy, whole grains and healthy fats, while limiting highly processed foods, added sugars and refined grains. A few habits cover most of it:

- **Protein at every meal:** eggs, fish, poultry, meat, beans, lentils, tofu, dairy, nuts.
- **Vegetables and fruit every day**, in many colors. Fresh, frozen and canned all count (look for no added sugar or salt).
- **Choose whole grains** (oats, brown rice, whole-wheat bread) over refined white versions.
- **Cut back on highly processed foods**: sweets, chips, sugary drinks, many packaged snacks and fast food.
- **Drink water** instead of sugary drinks. *(WL-05)*
- **Watch the salt:** most of it comes from packaged and restaurant food, not the shaker.

2. A SIMPLE WAY TO BUILD A MEAL

PART OF THE PLATE	WHAT GOES THERE	EXAMPLES
About half	Vegetables and fruit	Salad, green beans, carrots, broccoli, an apple, berries.
About a quarter	Protein	Chicken, fish, eggs, beans, lean beef, tofu.
About a quarter	Whole grains or starchy vegetables	Brown rice, whole-wheat pasta, potatoes, corn, oats.
On the side	Dairy and healthy fats	Milk, yogurt or cheese; olive oil, nuts, avocado.

Portions depend on age, size, activity and health. A dietitian can give you numbers that fit you.

3. READING THE NUTRITION FACTS LABEL

LOOK AT	WHAT IT TELLS YOU
1. Serving size	Everything on the label is for **this amount**. Many packages hold more than one serving: if you eat two, double every number.
2. Calories	Energy per serving. Labels use 2,000 calories a day as a general reference; your needs may be higher or lower.
3. % Daily Value	**5% DV or less is low; 20% DV or more is high.** Look for low in saturated fat, sodium and added sugars; high in fiber, vitamin D, calcium, iron and potassium.
4. Added sugars	Sugar put in during processing (not the sugar naturally in fruit or milk). Lower is better.

5. Sodium	The Daily Value is 2,300 mg. One serving of soup or a frozen meal can be a third or more of that.
6. Ingredients	Listed from most to least by weight. If sugar, or several kinds of sugar (syrups, words ending in "-ose"), are near the top, it's a sweet food.

QUICK COMPARE: holding two similar products, check the serving size first, then compare sodium, added sugars and fiber. Pick the one with less of the first two and more of the third.

4. DATES ON PACKAGES

- "Best if used by" is about **quality**, not safety. Most shelf-stable foods are safe after this date if stored well and the package is intact.
- "Use by" on infant formula is about safety: don't use it after the date.
- Throw out cans that are bulging, leaking or badly dented, and anything that smells or looks wrong.
- Rotate stored food: oldest first. *(TL-02, DC-06)*

5. MY FOOD NOTES

Foods I want to eat more of	
Foods I want to cut back on	
Allergies / foods to avoid	
One change I'll make this week	

SOURCES / FURTHER REFERENCE

1. U.S. Departments of Health and Human Services and Agriculture: Dietary Guidelines for Americans, 2025–2030. `dietaryguidelines.gov`
2. U.S. Food and Drug Administration: How to Understand and Use the Nutrition Facts Label; Sodium in Your Diet; Added Sugars. `fda.gov`
3. USDA Food Safety and Inspection Service: Food Product Dating. `fsis.usda.gov`

IMPORTANT: People with diabetes, kidney disease, heart disease, food allergies, or who are pregnant or nursing may need different advice. Ask your provider or a registered dietitian.